

By April 1945, Japanese commanders were herding idealistic young men to the slaughter in droves. As the Americans began their invasion of Okinawa, a force of over 2,000 aircraft dedicated to suicide attacks was assembled on the southern Japanese island of Kyushu under the command of Admiral Matome Ugaki. They were launched in mass attacks on the US fleet, hundreds of planes at a time attempting to overwhelm the American defenses. The pilots for these *kikusui* (“floating chrysanthemum”) raids were often recently drafted students who barely knew how to fly. Kanoya, the main naval air-force base on Kyushu, was under constant threat from B-29 bomber raids. The pilots were housed in half-ruined buildings, bedding down on the bare floor. In these uncomfortable and insecure surroundings, they awaited their first and last mission, most convinced that their death would be honorable and worthwhile.

Kamikaze legacy

Kamikaze attacks undeniably had both a psychological and physical impact on the US fleet. The bewilderment and sheer terror experienced by sailors when they first encountered suicide bombing cannot be quantified, although it never undermined their disciplined response. The physical damage is estimated at 34 vessels sunk and 288 damaged – a considerable battering for the US Navy and, in the later stages, its British allies. After the war, the US Strategic Bombing Survey concluded that if the attacks had been carried out “in greater power and concentration they might have been able to cause us to withdraw...” But Japan did not have the resources to sustain mass suicide bombing for long. Whereas on April 6 and 7, 1945, at the height of the kamikaze frenzy, more than 300 planes a day attacked the US fleet, by June the Japanese were hard pressed to find 50 aircraft for a raid. Some 2,000 Japanese aircraft and pilots were lost in suicide attacks, far more than could be replaced.

In the end, pitting the samurai spirit of heroic self-sacrifice against overwhelming industrial might was bound to fail. The Americans organized better for production and for combat. Commanders who valued the lives of their men – and airmen who valued their own lives – fought more effectively than those who glorified death in battle.

When the Japanese emperor broadcast his country’s surrender on August 15, 1945, kamikaze commander Admiral Ugaki took off with 10 other pilots on a final suicide mission. On his aircraft radio he announced: “I am going to make an attack on Okinawa where my men have fallen like cherry blossoms. There I will crash into and destroy the hated enemy in the true spirit of Bushido...” The admiral and his pilots were never seen again.

WWII US CARRIER AIRCRAFT

THE COMPLEMENT OF aircraft on a WWII US Navy carrier was largely made up of three types: dive-bombers, torpedo-bombers, and fighters, whose role was to defend the fleet and escort the bombers to their targets. When the Pacific War began in 1941, the US Navy had recently re-equipped with monoplanes such as the Douglas Dauntless, Grumman Wildcat (rushed into British service as the Martlet), and Brewster Buffalo. Within two years these were being replaced by a new generation of aircraft, including the Curtiss Helldiver, Grumman Hellcat and Avenger, and Vought Corsair. Although not all immediately popular with pilots, they gave the Americans a clear qualitative advantage over the Japanese.



CORSAIRS READY TO GO
Operating aircraft off the crowded deck of a carrier – pictured here after World War II – required discipline and organization. See pages 228–29.

Brewster F2A-3 Buffalo

ENGINE	1,200hp Wright R-1820-40 Cyclone 9-cylinder radial		
WINGSPAN	35ft (10.7m)	LENGTH	26ft 4in (8m)
TOP SPEED	321mph (517kph)	CREW	1
ARMAMENT	4 x .5in machine guns		



The first monoplane fighter to serve on US Navy aircraft carriers, the Buffalo went into service in 1939. Most were released for export (British markings shown), notably to Finland, where they fought on the Axis side throughout the war. The shortcomings of the design for combat in the Pacific were soon recognized and it was rapidly replaced by the Wildcat.

Curtiss SB2C-3 Helldiver

The replacement for the Dauntless was in theory better in every way – it was faster, had a longer range, and could carry more bombs, which were held in an internal bay. But it was late being delivered and when it was, it did not work. There were so many problems that serious thought was given to canceling the program, but this was politically impossible. Eventually over 7,000 were delivered (and made to work) and it became, by weight of numbers, the most widely used Allied dive-bomber of the war. That failed to stop pilots from saying that SB2C stood for “Son of a Bitch, 2nd Class.”

ENGINE	1,900hp Wright R-2600-20 Cyclone 14-cylinder radial		
WINGSPAN	49ft 8in (15.1m)	LENGTH	36ft 8in (11.2m)
TOP SPEED	293mph (472kph)	CREW	2
ARMAMENT	2 x 20mm cannon, 2 x .3in machine guns; 2,000lb (907kg) bombload or torpedoes, 2 x 500lb (227kg) bombs under wings		

